

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Tyrannidae

Tyrant flycatchers

Length 2–15 in (5–38 cm)

Species 433



This large family is very diverse and some experts split it into even more species. It contains the world's smallest passerine, the short-tailed pygmy-tyrant, which is just 2 in (5 cm) long with a wingspan of 1½ in (3.5 cm). However, within this large and varied family, body sizes vary widely and include many medium-sized birds. This family is found

from the taiga of Alaska, south through North America and the West Indies to the southern tip of South America, and in offshore islands including the Galapagos. However, the vast majority occur in Central and South America, with only 30 species breeding in North America; all the North American species migrate south in the autumn. Tyrant flycatchers have drab plumage overall and the sexes look similar. There are exceptions, however, with some species having colorful crown patches. Most members of the family are insect-eaters, but some catch frogs and lizards, and tropical species regularly eat fruit. Most tyrant flycatchers form monogamous pairs and many have courtship displays

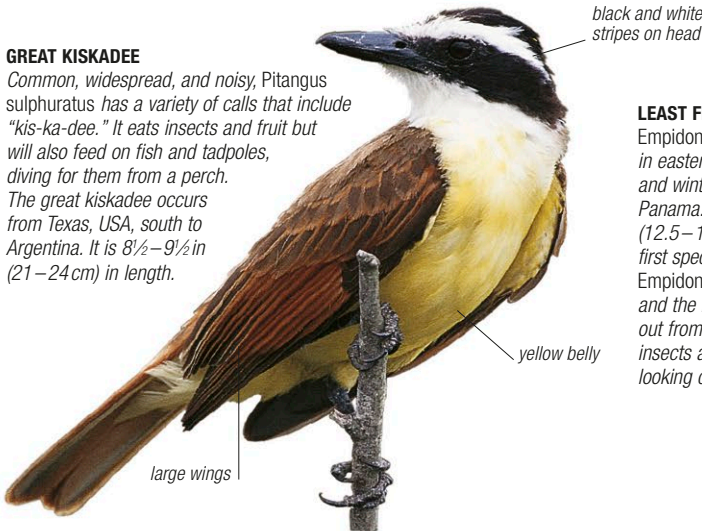
that involve wing-stretching or flicking. These birds are not colonial nesters, and their nests vary considerably: many build a simple cup in a tree fork, but some create large, hanging nests suspended from a branch; quite a few nest in cavities. Female tyrant flycatchers in the neotropics lay 2 or 3 eggs, but the clutches can be larger in North America. Females incubate their eggs for 14–20 days and the nestlings fledge in 14–23 days. Usually, both sexes build the nest and feed the young.

EASTERN KINGBIRD
Tyrannus tyrannus, 28 in (20 cm) long, breeds in North America and winters in Central and South America. It eats insects in summer and fruit in winter. Renowned for its vigorous defense of territory, it often attacks other birds, even landing on their backs in flight to inflict blows.



COMMON TODY-FLYCATCHER
Todirostrum cinereum, moves quickly among leaves as it catches insects. It can look quite comical as it hops and flutters about, perpetually in motion. It measures 3½ in (9 cm) in length, and occurs in Central America and parts of South America.

GREAT KISKADEE
Pitangus sulphuratus has a variety of calls that include "kis-ka-dee." It eats insects and fruit but will also feed on fish and tadpoles, diving for them from a perch. The great kiskadee occurs from Texas, USA, south to Argentina. It is 8½–9½ in (21–24 cm) in length.



LEAST FLYCATCHER
Empidonax minimus breeds in eastern Canada and the USA, and winters from Mexico to Panama. This bird, 5–5½ in (12.5–14.5 cm) long, is the first species of the genus *Empidonax* to migrate north and the last to fly south. It flies out from perches to catch insects and builds a frail-looking cup nest in a tree fork.



SCISSOR-TAILED FLYCATCHER
In its courtship sky dance, *Tyrannus forficatus* executes vertical and zigzag dives and tumbles, its long tail feathers streaming like ribbons. These aerobatics are accompanied by rolling cackles that sound like applause. Found in North and Central America, this species is 12–15 in (30–38 cm) long; the female has a shorter tail.



EASTERN PHOEBE
Sayornis phoebe, which measures 7 in (18 cm) in length, gets its name from its hoarse "fee-bee" song. This bird is found in the USA, Canada, and Mexico. It hunts over farmland and wooded roadsides, sallying after insects and wagging its tail when it alights. It may hover briefly over water when chasing flies.

Family Pipridae

Manakins

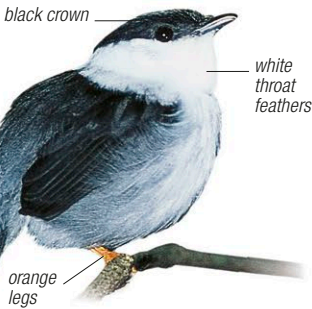
Length 3½–6 in (9–15 cm)

Species 52



Small birds with proportionately big heads, short tails, and broad, slightly hooked bill, manakins are found mainly in the lowlands of Central and South America. Males are generally brightly colored, often black with solid patches of blue, red, yellow, or orange. Females are usually greenish. Males of certain species have modified feathers that can

produce a mechanical noise during courtship. The male wire-tailed manakin uses his long, curved, wirelike tail feathers to tickle the throat of a visiting female. Males of some species gather in leks to display to females, either on the ground or on a branch. Successful males mate with several females. The female alone builds the nest—a woven cup in a horizontal tree fork—incubates the eggs, and feeds the young. She generally lays 2 eggs that hatch after 12–15 days. The nestlings feed on insects, but adults feed mainly on fruit, plucking these on the wing. All manakins that have been studied are sedentary and do not migrate.



WHITE-BEARDED MANAKIN
At a lek, the male *Manacus manacus*, using a sapling as the display perch, performs stylized jumps and produces noises with his wing feathers. This South American bird is 4 in (10 cm) long.



BLUE-BACKED MANAKIN
Chiroxiphia pareola, 4¼ in (12 cm) long, is found in South America. Two males often display by jumping over each other on branches; the winner makes short, circular courtship flights.